

SCCM / MECM Interview Questions & Answers

Beginner → Intermediate → Advanced

Below is a complete interview bank. Answers are written in **interview-ready English** so you can practice speaking them directly.

LEVEL 1: BEGINNER

1. What is SCCM?

Answer:

SCCM, now called **Microsoft Configuration Manager**, is a Microsoft endpoint management solution used to manage computers and devices in an organization. It can be used for software deployment, operating system deployment, software updates, inventory, compliance, and device management.

2. What is MECM?

Answer:

MECM stands for **Microsoft Endpoint Configuration Manager**. Microsoft has since renamed the product to **Microsoft Configuration Manager**. In many organizations, people still use the terms SCCM, MECM, and ConfigMgr interchangeably.

3. What is the difference between SCCM and MECM?

Answer:

They refer to the same Microsoft endpoint management product across different naming periods. SCCM was the older commonly used name, while MECM was a later name. The current product name is Microsoft Configuration Manager.

4. What can SCCM/MECM do?

Answer:

- Application deployment
 - Software updates
 - Operating system deployment
 - Hardware and software inventory
 - Compliance management
 - Configuration baselines
 - Client management
 - Reporting
 - Device collections
-

5. What is a Primary Site?

Answer:

A Primary Site is a major site in Configuration Manager that manages clients and provides management functionality for an organization. It communicates with clients through site systems such as Management Points and Distribution Points.

6. What is a Management Point?

Answer:

A **Management Point, or MP**, is a site system role that provides management communication between Configuration Manager clients and the site. Clients use the MP to obtain policies and send information such as inventory and status messages.

7. What is a Distribution Point?

Answer:

A **Distribution Point, or DP**, stores and distributes content such as applications, packages, software updates, and operating system files to clients.

8. What is the difference between MP and DP?

MP

Provides management communication

Delivers policies

Receives client information

Does not primarily act as content storage

DP

Provides content

Stores deployment content

Provides files to clients

Primarily acts as content distribution

9. What is SUP?

Answer:

SUP stands for **Software Update Point**. It integrates Configuration Manager with **WSUS** and is used to synchronize and manage software updates.

10. What is WSUS?

Answer:

WSUS stands for **Windows Server Update Services**. It provides Microsoft update synchronization and update metadata. Configuration Manager can use WSUS through the Software Update Point for software update management.

11. What is a Configuration Manager client?

Answer:

The Configuration Manager client is software installed on managed devices. It communicates with Configuration Manager infrastructure, receives policies, evaluates deployments, reports inventory, and performs management activities.

12. What is Software Center?

Answer:

Software Center is the client-side interface where users can view and install applications, software updates, operating systems, and other deployments made available to them.

13. What is a Collection?

Answer:

A collection is a group of devices or users in Configuration Manager. Collections are commonly used to target deployments, policies, applications, updates, and configuration baselines.

14. What is the difference between Device Collection and User Collection?

Answer:

A **Device Collection** contains computers or devices, while a **User Collection** contains users. Deployments can be targeted based on either users or devices.

15. What is a Boundary?

Answer:

A Boundary represents a network location or range of clients that Configuration Manager can use for management purposes. Examples include IP subnets, Active Directory sites, IP address ranges, and VPN-related configurations depending on the environment.

16. What is a Boundary Group?

Answer:

A Boundary Group groups boundaries together and helps Configuration Manager determine site assignment and preferred site systems such as Distribution Points.

17. What is Site Assignment?

Answer:

Site assignment determines which Configuration Manager site a client is assigned to. Proper boundary and boundary group configuration is important for client site assignment.

18. What is an Application in SCCM?

Answer:

An Application is a Configuration Manager deployment object used to deploy software. It can contain deployment types, requirements, dependencies, detection methods, and installation commands.

19. What is a Package?

Answer:

A Package is an older Configuration Manager software distribution model used to distribute files and execute programs. Unlike modern Applications, Packages do not provide the same application-management features such as detection methods and dependencies.

20. Application vs Package?

Answer:**Application:**

- Detection method
- Requirements
- Dependencies
- Deployment types
- More intelligent application management

Package:

- Primarily distributes content and runs programs
 - Simpler deployment model
 - Does not provide the same application model features
-

LEVEL 2: INTERMEDIATE

21. What is a Deployment Type?

Answer:

A Deployment Type defines how an application is installed. It contains information such as installation commands, uninstall commands, detection methods, requirements, and dependencies.

22. What is a Detection Method?

Answer:

A detection method determines whether an application is already installed on a device. Configuration Manager uses the detection result to determine whether the application needs to be installed.

23. Why is a detection method important?

Answer:

It prevents unnecessary installation and helps Configuration Manager determine the correct application state. An incorrect detection method can cause repeated installations or incorrect compliance results.

24. What is a Requirement Rule?

Answer:

A requirement rule defines conditions that a device must satisfy before an application can be installed. Examples include operating system version, disk space, architecture, or other supported conditions.

25. What is an Application Dependency?

Answer:

A dependency is another application or component that must be installed before the main application can be installed.

Example:

An application may require a specific runtime component before installation.

26. What is Content in SCCM?

Answer:

Content is the files required by a deployment, such as application installation files, packages, drivers, update files, or operating system images.

27. What is Content Distribution?

Answer:

Content distribution is the process of transferring deployment content from the Configuration Manager infrastructure to Distribution Points so clients can download and use it.

28. What is a Distribution Point Group?

Answer:

A Distribution Point Group is a logical collection of Distribution Points. Content can be distributed to the group instead of selecting each Distribution Point individually.

29. What is an ADR?

Answer:

ADR stands for **Automatic Deployment Rule**. It automates the selection and deployment of software updates based on defined criteria.

30. What is Software Update Group?

Answer:

A Software Update Group is a logical collection of software updates that can be deployed and managed together.

31. What is a Deployment Package?

Answer:

A deployment package contains software update files that Configuration Manager distributes to Distribution Points.

32. What is a Task Sequence?

Answer:

A Task Sequence is a series of steps used to automate complex tasks such as operating system deployment, software installation, configuration, and migration.

33. What is OSD?

Answer:

OSD stands for **Operating System Deployment**. It is used to deploy Windows operating systems to computers using Configuration Manager Task Sequences.

34. What is PXE?

Answer:

PXE stands for **Preboot Execution Environment**. It allows a computer to boot from the network instead of local storage. Configuration Manager can use PXE to start operating system deployment.

35. What is a Boot Image?

Answer:

A Boot Image is a Windows PE-based image used to start a computer during operating system deployment and provide the environment required to run the Task Sequence.

36. What is an Operating System Image?

Answer:

An Operating System Image contains the Windows operating system files that are applied to the target computer during OSD.

37. What are Driver Packages?

Answer:

Driver Packages contain device drivers required during operating system deployment or for managing hardware devices.

38. What is Hardware Inventory?

Answer:

Hardware Inventory collects information about the hardware configuration of managed devices, such as processor, memory, disk, BIOS, and hardware components.

39. What is Software Inventory?

Answer:

Software Inventory collects information about selected files on client computers. It is different from hardware inventory and is not the primary mechanism for discovering installed applications.

40. What is Configuration Baseline?

Answer:

A Configuration Baseline is used to evaluate whether devices comply with defined configuration requirements. It can contain configuration items and compliance rules.

LEVEL 3: ADVANCED

41. What is Co-management?

Answer:

Co-management allows an organization to manage Windows devices using both **Configuration Manager and Microsoft Intune**. Different workloads can be managed by Configuration Manager, Intune, or both depending on the organization's configuration.

42. What is Microsoft Intune?

Answer:

Microsoft Intune is a cloud-based endpoint management service used to manage devices, applications, policies, compliance, and security settings.

43. What is Cloud Management Gateway?

Answer:

A **Cloud Management Gateway, or CMG**, allows Configuration Manager clients on the internet to communicate with the Configuration Manager infrastructure without requiring a traditional VPN connection to the corporate network.

44. Why is CMG used?

Answer:

CMG is useful when organizations need to manage internet-based clients. It provides a cloud-based communication path for supported Configuration Manager client management scenarios.

45. What is Tenant Attach?

Answer:

Tenant attach connects Configuration Manager with Microsoft Intune so administrators can view and manage certain Configuration Manager capabilities from the Microsoft Intune admin center.

46. What is PKI?

Answer:

PKI stands for **Public Key Infrastructure**. In Configuration Manager environments, certificates can be used to provide secure authentication and HTTPS communication.

47. Why is HTTPS important in Configuration Manager?

Answer:

HTTPS provides encrypted communication and certificate-based authentication for supported Configuration Manager communication scenarios. It is especially relevant when implementing secure client communication and internet-based management.

48. What is CAS?

Answer:

CAS stands for **Central Administration Site**. It is used in certain large Configuration Manager hierarchies to coordinate multiple Primary Sites.

A CAS does not directly manage clients.

49. CAS vs Primary Site?

Answer:

CAS:

- Central administrative layer
- Coordinates multiple Primary Sites
- Does not directly manage clients

Primary Site:

- Manages clients
 - Provides site functionality
 - Communicates with clients through site systems
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50. Can a Primary Site exist without a CAS?

Answer:

Yes. A standalone Primary Site can be used when the environment does not require a multi-primary-site hierarchy.



TROUBLESHOOTING QUESTIONS

51. Application is not appearing in Software Center. What will you check?

Answer:

I would check:

1. Client health

2. Client policy
 3. Deployment targeting
 4. Collection membership
 5. Boundary and Boundary Group
 6. Application requirements
 7. Deployment availability settings
 8. Application detection method
 9. Management Point communication
 10. Relevant client logs
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52. Application is showing in Software Center but installation fails. What will you check?

Answer:

I would check:

- Application deployment status
 - Content availability on DP
 - Installation command
 - Detection method
 - Requirements
 - Dependencies
 - User permissions
 - Installer logs
 - Configuration Manager client logs
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53. Client is not receiving policy. What will you check?

Answer:

I would check:

- Client service
- Management Point communication
- Client registration
- Boundary configuration
- Network connectivity
- DNS
- Client policy retrieval
- Client logs

I would also manually trigger a Machine Policy Retrieval & Evaluation cycle when appropriate.

54. Client is showing inactive. What will you check?

Answer:

I would check:

- Client service
- Network connectivity
- Management Point communication
- Client installation/health
- Last policy request
- Hardware inventory activity
- Client logs

55. Software update is not installing. What will you check?

Answer:

I would check:

- Update deployment
- Collection membership
- Software Update Group
- Deployment deadline
- Update applicability
- SUP/WSUS health
- Boundary and DP configuration
- Content availability
- Client update logs

56. PXE boot is not working. What will you check?

Answer:

I would check:

1. PXE-enabled Distribution Point
2. Boot image distribution
3. Network/DHCP configuration
4. IP helper configuration where applicable

5. Boundary and Boundary Group
 6. Task Sequence deployment
 7. Boot image availability
 8. PXE-related logs
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57. Task Sequence fails during OSD. What will you do?

Answer:

I would first identify the exact Task Sequence step where the failure occurred. Then I would review the Task Sequence progress and relevant logs, check network and content availability, verify drivers and boot image configuration, and determine whether the failure is related to the OS image, application, driver, disk, or connectivity.



SCENARIO-BASED QUESTIONS

58. A new application must be deployed to 1,000 computers. How would you approach it?

Answer:

I would:

1. Create the application.
 2. Configure the deployment type.
 3. Configure installation and uninstall commands.
 4. Configure the detection method.
 5. Distribute content to appropriate DPs.
 6. Create or identify the target collection.
 7. Test with a pilot collection.
 8. Monitor deployment status.
 9. Expand deployment after successful testing.
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59. Users report that Software Center is empty. What would you investigate?

Answer:

I would investigate client health, policy retrieval, Management Point communication, user/device targeting, collection membership, deployment availability, and boundary configuration. I would

then review the appropriate client logs to identify where communication or policy processing is failing.

60. A client can communicate with the MP but cannot download application content. What could be wrong?

Answer:

The Management Point and Distribution Point perform different roles. I would check the DP assignment, Boundary Group configuration, content distribution status, content location returned to the client, network connectivity, and relevant content-transfer logs.

61. Application installs successfully but Software Center still shows it as required. Why?

Answer:

A common reason is an incorrect **detection method**. If Configuration Manager cannot detect the installed application correctly, it may believe the application is still missing and attempt to install it again.

62. Some clients receive an application but others do not. What would you check?

Answer:

I would compare the affected and working clients:

- Collection membership
 - Boundary Group
 - Client health
 - Policy
 - Application requirements
 - Dependencies
 - Content location
 - Operating system
 - Architecture
 - Network connectivity
-

63. How would you troubleshoot a Distribution Point content issue?

Answer:

I would verify that the content is successfully distributed to the DP, check Distribution Point status, confirm that the client can locate the DP, verify Boundary Group configuration, and review relevant server and client logs.

64. How would you troubleshoot an SCCM client installation failure?

Answer:

I would verify prerequisites, connectivity to the Management Point and required infrastructure, installation command-line parameters, permissions, certificates where applicable, and client installation logs. I would identify the exact installation error before making changes.

65. How do you monitor deployments?

Answer:

I use Configuration Manager monitoring and deployment status views to check success, in-progress, failed, and unknown states. I also investigate client-side logs when deployment status indicates a problem.



SCCM / MECM Production Interview Questions & Answers

1. MP vs DP

Question: What is the difference between Management Point and Distribution Point?

Answer:

A **Management Point (MP)** handles communication between Configuration Manager clients and the site. It provides client policy and receives client information such as inventory and status.

A **Distribution Point (DP)** stores and provides deployment content such as applications, packages, software updates, boot images, and OS images.

Interview line:

"MP is mainly for management communication and policy, while DP is mainly for content distribution."

2. Boundary vs Boundary Group

Question: What is the difference between Boundary and Boundary Group?

Answer:

A **Boundary** represents a network location such as an IP subnet, IP address range, or Active Directory site.

A **Boundary Group** is a logical group of boundaries. It is used for **site assignment and locating preferred site systems**, such as Distribution Points.

Interview line:

"Boundary identifies the network location, while Boundary Group uses those boundaries to determine site assignment and available site systems."

3. Application vs Package

Question: What is the difference between an Application and a Package?

Answer:

An **Application** is the modern application management model. It supports deployment types, detection methods, requirements, dependencies, and more intelligent application state management.

A **Package** is an older software distribution model primarily used to deliver content and execute programs.

Interview line:

"For modern software deployment, I would generally use Applications because they provide detection, requirements, dependencies, and deployment types."

4. Application Detection Method

Question: What is an Application Detection Method?

Answer:

A detection method tells Configuration Manager whether an application is already installed on the client.

For example, Configuration Manager can check:

- Registry
- File or folder
- Windows Installer product information
- Custom detection script

If the detection rule confirms that the application is installed, Configuration Manager considers the deployment detected.

Common problem:

If the detection method is incorrect, the application may repeatedly try to install or show an incorrect state in Software Center.

5. Application Deployment Troubleshooting

Question: An application is not installing. How would you troubleshoot it?

Answer:

I would follow a structured approach:

1. Check whether the device is in the correct collection.
2. Verify the deployment is targeted to the device or user.
3. Check client health.
4. Verify policy has reached the client.
5. Check application requirements.
6. Check dependencies.
7. Verify content is available on the DP.
8. Check the detection method.
9. Check the installation command.
10. Review client logs.

Important logs include:

- `AppDiscovery.log`
- `AppIntentEval.log`

- AppEnforce.log
 - CAS.log
 - ContentTransferManager.log
 - LocationServices.log
-

6. Software Update Troubleshooting

Question: A software update is not installing. What would you check?

Answer:

I would check:

1. Whether the update applies to the device.
2. Software Update Group deployment.
3. Deployment deadline.
4. Client policy.
5. SUP health.
6. WSUS synchronization.
7. Update content availability.
8. Boundary and DP configuration.
9. Windows Update Agent/client health.
10. Relevant logs.

Important logs:

- WUAHandler.log
 - UpdatesHandler.log
 - UpdatesDeployment.log
 - ScanAgent.log
 - LocationServices.log
-

7. SUP and WSUS

Question: What is SUP and how is it related to WSUS?

Answer:

SUP, or Software Update Point, is the Configuration Manager site system role used for software update management.

SUP integrates Configuration Manager with **WSUS**. WSUS provides Microsoft update synchronization and metadata, while Configuration Manager provides deployment, targeting, monitoring, and management capabilities.

Interview line:

"WSUS provides the update infrastructure and metadata, while Configuration Manager manages update deployment and administration."

8. ADR

Question: What is an ADR?

Answer:

ADR stands for **Automatic Deployment Rule**.

It automates the process of selecting software updates according to criteria and then creating or updating a Software Update Group and its deployment.

Example:

An organization can create an ADR to automatically select monthly security updates for supported Windows systems and deploy them to a test collection first.

Interview line:

"ADR reduces manual work by automating update selection and deployment based on defined rules."

9. Task Sequence

Question: What is a Task Sequence?

Answer:

A Task Sequence is a sequence of actions used to automate complex deployment and configuration tasks.

It can perform tasks such as:

- Partitioning a disk
- Applying an OS image
- Installing drivers

- Installing applications
- Applying updates
- Configuring Windows
- Joining a domain

Interview line:

"Task Sequence is mainly used to automate operating system deployment and other multi-step deployment processes."

10. PXE Troubleshooting

Question: A computer is not booting through PXE. How would you troubleshoot it?

Answer:

I would check:

1. Is the DP PXE-enabled?
2. Is the boot image distributed to the DP?
3. Is the Task Sequence deployed to the device?
4. Is the device in the correct collection?
5. Are Boundary Groups configured correctly?
6. Is network/DHCP configuration correct?
7. Are IP helpers required and correctly configured?
8. Is the client receiving a PXE response?
9. Check PXE-related logs on the DP.

Interview approach:

"I would first determine whether the failure occurs at network boot, PXE response, boot image download, or Task Sequence selection."

11. Client Troubleshooting

Question: A Configuration Manager client is not working. What would you check?

Answer:

I would check:

- CcmExec service
- Client installation
- Management Point communication
- Boundary assignment
- Client registration
- Policy retrieval
- Network connectivity
- DNS
- Certificates where applicable
- Client logs

I would also check whether the client is **active and properly assigned to the expected site**.

12. Content Distribution

Question: What is content distribution?

Answer:

Content distribution is the process of making deployment content available on Distribution Points.

For example, if I create an application, its installation files must be distributed to the appropriate DP before clients can download them.

Troubleshooting sequence:

Application → Content → DP → Boundary Group → Client → Download → Installation

13. CMG

Question: What is Cloud Management Gateway?

Answer:

CMG is a cloud-based Configuration Manager service that enables supported Configuration Manager clients on the internet to communicate with the Configuration Manager infrastructure without requiring a traditional VPN connection to the corporate network.

It is particularly useful for managing internet-based devices.

Interview line:

"CMG extends Configuration Manager client management to internet-based devices."

14. Co-management

Question: What is co-management?

Answer:

Co-management allows an organization to manage Windows devices using both **Configuration Manager and Microsoft Intune**.

An organization can gradually move supported management workloads from Configuration Manager to Intune.

Example workloads can include:

- Compliance policies
- Windows Update policies
- Endpoint protection
- Device configuration

The exact workload configuration depends on the organization's environment.

15. Tenant Attach

Question: What is Tenant Attach?

Answer:

Tenant Attach connects Configuration Manager with **Microsoft Intune** and allows administrators to access certain Configuration Manager information and capabilities through the Microsoft Intune admin center.

It provides cloud-based visibility and management capabilities without requiring every traditional Configuration Manager function to be moved to Intune.

16. Configuration Baseline

Question: What is a Configuration Baseline?

Answer:

A Configuration Baseline is used to evaluate whether devices comply with defined configuration requirements.

It contains **Configuration Items** that define the settings or conditions to evaluate.

Example:

An organization can use a baseline to check whether:

- A required security setting is enabled.
- A specific registry value exists.
- A required configuration is present.

The baseline can then report compliance status.

17. CAS vs Primary Site

Question: What is the difference between CAS and Primary Site?

Answer:

CAS

Central Administration Site

- Used in certain large Configuration Manager hierarchies.
- Provides central administration and coordination.
- Can connect multiple Primary Sites.
- Does not directly manage clients.

Primary Site

- Manages clients.
- Provides site functionality.
- Uses site systems such as MPs and DPs.
- Handles client-related management.

Interview line:

"The CAS provides central administration for a hierarchy, while the Primary Site is responsible for managing clients."

18. OSD Troubleshooting

Question: A Task Sequence fails during Operating System Deployment. How would you troubleshoot it?

Answer:

First, I would identify the exact Task Sequence step where the failure occurred.

Then I would check:

1. Network connectivity.
2. Boot image.
3. OS image.
4. Drivers.
5. Task Sequence variables.
6. Application/package content.
7. DP availability.
8. Disk configuration.
9. Domain join configuration.
10. Relevant Task Sequence logs.

I would avoid making random changes and first identify the **exact failed step and error code**.

19. SCCM/MECM Client Logs

Question: Which logs are important for troubleshooting?

Answer:

Some commonly used client logs are:

Log	Purpose
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AppDiscovery.log	Application detection
AppEnforce.log	Application installation enforcement
AppIntentEval.log	Application deployment evaluation
CAS.log	Content access
ContentTransferManager.log	Content transfer
LocationServices.log	MP/DP location information
PolicyAgent.log	Policy processing
PolicyEvaluator.log	Policy evaluation
WUAHandler.log	Windows Update Agent activity
UpdatesHandler.log	Software update handling
UpdatesDeployment.log	Software update deployment
ScanAgent.log	Software update scan

`InventoryAgent.log`

Hardware/software inventory

`execmgr.log`

Legacy package/program execution

Interview line:

"I select the log based on the problem rather than checking every log."

20. Real-World Deployment Scenario

Question: You need to deploy Chrome to 5,000 computers. How would you do it?

Answer:

I would follow a controlled deployment process:

Step 1: Create Application

Create the Chrome application in Configuration Manager.

Step 2: Configure Deployment Type

Configure the installer, installation command, uninstall command, requirements, and detection method.

Step 3: Distribute Content

Distribute the application content to the required Distribution Points.

Step 4: Create Pilot Collection

Create a small pilot collection containing representative devices.

Step 5: Deploy to Pilot

Deploy the application to the pilot collection.

Step 6: Monitor

Monitor:

- Success
- Failed
- In progress
- Unknown
- Detection status

Step 7: Troubleshoot

Investigate failures using the appropriate client logs.

Step 8: Production Deployment

After successful pilot validation, deploy to the required production collections according to the organization's change-management process.

Strong interview answer:

"I would not immediately deploy to all 5,000 devices. I would first validate the application, detection method, content distribution, and installation on a pilot collection, monitor the results, and then perform the production rollout."